

Session 28: Not Chosen But Blessed

Key Takeaways

- The theme of fractured relationship in the Avraham story is crucial for understanding the plight of humanity and for building the biblical hope of eventual reconciliation.
- Avraham's sojourns in Babylon and Egypt create a thematic link between the two. Israel's exodus from Egypt later becomes the hope for the nation's return from exile in Babylon.

Macro Design of Genesis 25:1-18

Genesis 25:1-6

- **25:1** Avraham marries Qeturah
- **Birth: Sons of Qeturah**
 - **25:2-4** Qeturah births 16 sons and grandsons for Avraham
- **Brothers Divide**
 - **25:6** Avraham separates Yitskhaq away from sons of concubines who go east

Genesis 25:7-11

- **Death**
 - **25:7-8** Avraham expires at 175 years, buried and gathered to his people
- **25:9-10** Yitskhaq and Yishmael bury Avraham in cave/field of Makpelah in Mamre
- **Brothers Divide**
 - **25:11** Yitskhaq is selected for blessing and lives in Yishmael's old haunt

Genesis 25:12-18

- **Birth: Sons of Yishmael**
 - **25:12-16** Yishmael's birth generations: 12 sons (grandsons of Avraham)
- **Death**
 - **25:17** Yishmael expires at 137 years, buried and gathered to his people
- **Brothers Divide**
 - **25:18** Yishmaelites live in south, away from his brothers

Genesis 25:1-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avraham's Marriage to Qeturah

These three units bring the Avraham story to a close, and they are tightly woven together in a number of ways that recall the same type of conclusion to the Adam and Eve story in Genesis 4-5, and the Noah story in Genesis 10-11

God Blesses the Chosen One, Who Eventually Fails	God Chooses One From the Next Generation; Brothers Divide, One to the East	Genealogy of Births and Deaths	Selection and Blessing of the Next Generation
Adam & Eve (Gen. 2-3)	Cain, Abel, Seth (Gen. 4)	Gen. 5 These are the birth generations	Noah (Gen. 6-8)
Noah (Gen. 9:1-17)	Japheth, Shem, Ham (Gen. 9:18-29)	Gen. 10 These are the birth generations	Avraham (Gen. 11:27-12:6)
Avraham & Sarah (Gen. 11-24)	Yishmael, Yitskhaq, and sons of Qeturah (Gen. 25:1-18)	Gen. 25 These are the birth generations	Yitskhaq (Gen. 25:5-6, 11)

Three Cycles of the Pattern. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 25:1-18

¹ And Avraham did it again, and he took a wife, and her name was Qeturah.

- a ² And she birthed for him
- b Zimran and Yoqshan and Medan and Midyan and Yishbaq and Shuakh,
- c ³ and Yoqshan birthed Sheva and Dedan,
- c' and the sons of Dedan were Ashurites, Letushites, and Leummites;
- b' ⁴ and the sons of Midyan were Ephah and Epher and Enoch and Avida and Eldaah.
- a' All these are the sons of Qeturah.

- a 5 **And Avraham gave all** that belong to him
 b **to Yitskhaq**,
 b' 6 **and to the sons of the concubines** of Avraham,
 a' **Avraham gave gifts**,
 a and he sent them away from Yitskhaq his son,
 b while he was still alive,
 a' **to the east (קדמה)**, **to the land of the east (קדם)**.

- a 7 **And these are the days of the years of the life of Avraham** which he **lived**:
 b one hundred years and **seventy (שבע)** years and five years.
 a' 8 And he **expired** and **Avraham died**,
 b' in good old age,
 b'' old and **complete (שבע)**,
 a'' and he was **gathered to his people**.

- a 9 And they **buried him**, **Yitskhaq and Yishmael, his sons**,
 b in the cave of Macpelah,
 c in **the field** of Ephron son of Zohar that **Hethite**,
 b' which is opposite Mamre,
 c' 10 **the field** which Avraham purchased from the sons of **Heth**,
 a there **were buried Avraham** and Sarah his wife.

- 11 And it came about after the **death of Avraham**,
 that Elohim **blessed Yitskhaq his son**,
and Yitskhaq dwelt at Well of the Living One Who Sees Me.

- 12 **And these are the birth-generations of Yishmael, son of Avraham**,
 whom **she birthed**, Hagar the Egyptian, the slave-girl of Sarah, for Avraham.
 13 **These are the names of the sons of Yishmael**,
by their names of their birth-generations:
 the firstborn of Yishmael: Nevayot
 and Qedar and Adbeel and Mivsam,
 14 and Mishma and Dumah and Massa,
 15 Khadad and Tema, Yetur, Naphish, and **Qedmah (קדמה)**.
 16 **These are the sons of Yishmael and these are their names**,
by their villages and encampments,
twelve princes according to their clans.

- 17 **And these are the years of the life of Yishmael**:
 One hundred years and thirty years and **seven (שבע)** years.

And **he expired and he died, and he was gathered to his people** .

18 **And they dwelt from Havilah unto Shur** ,
which is opposite Egypt as you go to **Ashur** ,
against the face of all his brothers he fell.

Genesis 25:1-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Brothers From Different Mothers

This design sets up a paired relationship between Avraham's sons through Hagar and Qeturah, both in contrast to Yitskhaq. They all dwell in the south and east of the land of Canaan where Yitskhaq lives. Notice the wordplay between the sons of Qeturah who live in the east (קדמה) and the last son of Yishmael who is named "east" (קדמה).

The "sending away" of the sons of Qeturah from Yitskhaq is also parallel to the sons of Yishmael "falling against the face all his brothers." The vocabulary of these opening and closing sections of Genesis 25:1-18 is closely aligned with the story of Adam and Eve and Qayin's expulsion from Eden.

Gen. 25:6b And he sent them away (וישלחם)	Adam: Gen. 3:23a And Yahweh sent [human] away (וישלחהו) Cain: Gen. 4:14 Behold you have banished me (גרשת אתי)
from (מעל) Isaac while he was still living (עודנו חי)	Adam: Gen. 3:23b from the garden of Eden (עדן) Cain: Gen. 4:14 from upon the face of (מעל פני) the land and from before you (ומפניך)
to the east (קדמה) , to the land of the east (קדם)	Adam: Gen. 3:24 And he stationed on the east (מקדם) , the cherubim ... to guard the way to the tree of life (חי) Cain: Gen. 4:16 And Cain went out (ויצא) ... and dwelt in the land of Nod (נוד // עדן) , east of Eden (קדמת עדן)

Sent Away Sons. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The descendants of Qeturah and Yishmael are also set on analogy with the sons of Ham in Genesis 10, through the not-so-subtle repetition of names.

Descendants of Ham

- Dedan and Sheva (Gen. 10:7)
- Havilah (Gen. 10:7)
- Ashur (Assyria, Gen. 10:11)

- Egypt ("Mizraim," Gen. 10:6).

Descendants of Avraham Through Qeturah

- Sheva and Dedan (Gen. 25:3)
- Ashurim (Gen. 25:3)

Descendants of Avraham Through Yishmael

"And they lived from Havilah unto Shur, which is before Egypt as one goes to Ashur" (Gen. 25:18).

These sons of Avraham are likened to the sons of Ham, who will live at odds with the chosen line of Avraham near their borders.

Non-Chosen but Blessed

Remember that in Genesis 16-17, Avraham asked God to favor Yishmael as the chosen son. God responded that Yishmael would indeed experience the Eden blessing, but he would not be chosen as the vehicle of promised lineage.

Genesis 17:18-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁸ And Avraham said to God, "Oh that Yishmael might live before you!" ¹⁹ But God said, "No. Sarah your wife will bear you a son, and you shall call his name Isaac; and I will establish my covenant with him for an everlasting covenant for his seed after him. ²⁰ As for Yishmael, I have heard you; look, I will bless him, and will make him fruitful and will multiply very much; **he shall become the father of twelve rulers**, and I will make him a great nation."

Genesis 25:12-16 Instructor's Translation

¹² And these are the birth-generations of Yishmael, son of Avraham, whom she birthed, Hagar the Egyptian, the slave-girl of Sarah, for Avraham. ¹³ These are the names of the sons of Yishmael, by their names of their birth-generations:
the firstborn of Yishmael:

Nevayot and Qedar and Adbeel and Mivsham, ¹⁴ and Mishma and Dumah and Massa, ¹⁵ Khadad and Tema, Yetur, Naphish, and Qedemah.

¹⁶ These are the sons of Yishmael and these are their names, by their villages and encampments, twelve rulers according to their clans.

Reflection Question

How is Avraham's story relevant for people of God who are so far removed from his time and situation?